to reporters.[1] Kashmir's most ardent Muslim youth, however, viewed Farooq's realism as cowardice or capitulation to New Delhi's pressures and temptations, joining together in a Muslim United Front, including the Jamaat-i-Islami and other Islamic fundamentalist groups led by the popular Kashmiri preachers Qazi Nissar and Maulvi Abbas Ansari. The rigging of elections in 1987 proved so blatant that many of Kashmir's most popular young Muslims, like Abdul Ghani Lone, lost their bids for Assembly seats only because police arrested most of their followers at polling stations, persuading young idealists to turn to bullets after seeing the ballot fail them. Pakistan's ISI was ready to help train those young Kashmiris in any and every way possible, offering them weapons and exercises in urban insurrection, eager to undermine India's power in the Vale of Kashmir at such relatively little expense to themselves.

In December 1989, the daughter of Kashmiri Home Minister Mufti Mohammad Sayeed was kidnapped by several members of the Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF), who demanded the release of all their leaders from prison in return for her life. Foreign Minister Inder Kumar Gujral flew to Srinagar to arrange for Rubaiya Sayeed's release. Her safe return was warmly welcomed by most members of the government in Delhi, though some now view it as "abject surrender" to Kashmiri "militants," which only helped to make them bolder in later actions and demands.[2] In 1990, Jagmohan was flown back to Srinagar as Kashmir's governor, inducing Chief Minister Farooq to resign immediately, launching a second, harsher phase of official terror throughout the Vale. Jagmohan insisted that the bullet was the "only solution" for Kashmir's militants, ordering his troops to fire at anyone daring to break his curfew or violate his draconian orders. The former happy valley returned to its darkest night of fear and terror. Hindu pandits and moderate Muslims fled from "the Wounded Valley."[3] The Indian flag was raised over an empty central square in Srinagar, guarded by heavily armed troops on Republic Day, 26 January 1992, symbolizing the total alienation of Kashmiris from New Delhi's autocratic regime.

Four young Muslim freedom-fighters had now emerged in Srinagar as the most popular leaders of Kashmir: Hamid Sheikh, Ashfaq Wani, Javed Mir, and Yasin Malik. Ashfaq Wani, a member of the Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front, was only twenty-three when he was gunned down by Indian soldiers in March 1990. His coffin was followed by half a million silent mourners who ignored curfew orders to remain indoors, marching defiantly behind the body to Srinagar's cemetery. Thousands